Political novice or simply a shy recluse, the family surname was enough for Rahul to win his first election from Amethi very easily. What was more surprising was that the Congress and its allies emerged as the leading pre-poll grouping, leaving all opinion pollsters wondering where they'd gone so horribly wrong. The 'aam aadmi' plank had got the better of India Shining, and flawed alliances in Andhra and Tamil Nadu contributed to the Vajpayee government's shock defeat. That wasn't the only surprise. In a political masterstroke, Sonia Gandhi decided she would forego her prime ministerial claims, and chose Manmohan Singh as her nominee. She had listened, she claimed, to her 'inner voice'. With that one decision, she buried the debate over her foreign origins, achieved the halo of apparent renunciation and blunted, at least for the moment, the BJP's searing attack on her.

While Mrs Gandhi continued to wield enormous power as the UPA chairperson, Rahul did a disappearing act of sorts. Between 2004 and 2007, he was hardly seen in and outside Parliament. In the fourteenth Lok Sabha, Rahul participated in just five debates, asked just three questions, did not present a single private members' bill, and attended only 63 per cent of the Lok Sabha proceedings, well below the average attendance. In an interview to *Tehelka* magazine at the time (the Congress later denied that any interview was given, saying it was only a 'casual conversation'), Rahul was quoted as saying, 'I don't ask questions in Parliament because I like to think things through. Just look around at the questions that are asked in Parliament and you will know why I don't ask questions!' Sounding condescending and arrogant in equal measure, Rahul even controversially claimed in that interview, 'I could have been prime minister if I wanted at the age of twenty-five years!'

The one memorable Rahul intervention in Parliament came in 2008 during the Indo-US nuclear debate. Linking poverty to energy security, Rahul invoked the hardships of a Dalit woman Kalavati whom he had met during a tour of Maharashtra's drought-prone Vidarbha region. Kalavati's husband had committed suicide like hundreds of other farmers, and Rahul spoke passionately of the need to empower Kalavati. In a foreign policy debate on nuclear energy, Rahul had struck an emotional chord. But the